

Zepbound (tirzepatide) — Patient Information

Purpose of Treatment

Zepbound is used to promote weight loss by decreasing appetite, increasing the feeling of fullness (satiety), and slowing stomach emptying. It acts on two hormone receptors (GIP and GLP-1) and also reduces cravings and the appeal of sugary and fatty foods.

Nature of Treatment and Cost

Treatment is generally chronic (long-term) in order to maintain the weight-related benefits. It is an injection under the skin once weekly, using a multi-dose pen containing 4 doses (one pen per month).

The cost without insurance is approximately \$300 to \$540 per month depending on the dose. It is not covered by RAMQ or public plans; about one in three private plans covers it — check with your insurer. The manufacturer's program (myZepbound) can reduce the cost for eligible patients.

No generic version of tirzepatide is expected for several years.

Common (Expected) Side Effects

These effects are generally transient and occur mainly at the beginning of treatment or when the dose is increased.

Digestive:

- Nausea: 25–29%
- Diarrhea: 19–23%
- Constipation: 11–17%
- Vomiting: 8–13%
- Abdominal pain: 9–10%
- Dyspepsia (indigestion): 9–10%
- Belching: 4–6%
- Reflux: 4–5%
- Gas and bloating: 3–4%

Other:

- Injection site reactions: 6–8%
- Fatigue: 5–7%
- Dizziness: 4–6%
- Mild to moderate hair loss: 4–5%
- Increased lipase (+34% on average) and amylase (+23%) — usually of no consequence
- Slight increase in resting heart rate (~3 beats/minute on average)
- Hypoglycemia: ~4% if you are on diabetes treatment (up to 10% in combination with a sulfonylurea — your physician may reduce your other diabetes medications)

Tips to Improve Tolerance

- Eat slowly and in small amounts
- Avoid fatty meals at the beginning of treatment
- Follow the gradual dose escalation schedule
- Maintain good hydration (particularly important: dehydration can affect the kidneys)

Rare but Important Side Effects

Pancreatitis: a rare but potentially serious complication

Pancreatitis is a rare side effect of Zepbound (about 0.2% in studies). Seek care promptly in case of severe, persistent pain in the abdomen or back, with or without vomiting.

Gallbladder disease (~1–2%)

Gallstones and gallbladder inflammation, associated with rapid weight loss. Intense pain in the abdomen, right shoulder, or between the shoulder blades; seek immediate care if the pain is accompanied by yellowing skin or fever with chills.

Dehydration and kidneys

Significant nausea, vomiting, or diarrhea can lead to dehydration and, rarely, acute kidney failure (0.5%). Drink plenty of fluids.

Retinopathy (in patients with diabetes)

May occur if blood sugar improves rapidly. Watch for visual symptoms.

Thyroid cancer (very rare, not demonstrated in humans)

A signal observed in animal studies. Avoid if you have a personal or family history of medullary thyroid carcinoma or MEN2 syndrome.

Other rare effects

Severe slowing of stomach emptying (gastroparesis) or intestinal blockage; serious allergic reactions (swelling of the face or throat, difficulty breathing); mood changes or dark thoughts — reported with weight-loss medications: seek care without delay if you or your loved ones notice an unusual change.

Special Precautions

- **Oral contraceptives:** their effectiveness may be temporarily reduced. Use a non-oral method or add a barrier method (condoms) for the 4 weeks after starting treatment and after each dose increase.
- **Pregnancy and breastfeeding:** contraindicated. Stop treatment at least 1 month before a planned pregnancy.
- **Surgery or sedation:** tell your healthcare team that you take Zepbound before any procedure requiring anesthesia (the stomach empties more slowly).

When to Seek Prompt Medical Attention

- Severe, persistent abdominal pain
- Significant vomiting or signs of dehydration (dizziness, dark urine)
- Intense abdominal pain with yellowing skin or fever and chills
- Visual disturbances
- A lump in the neck or difficulty swallowing
- Allergic reaction (swelling of the face or throat, difficulty breathing)
- Unusual change in mood or dark thoughts

Differences Compared to Wegovy

- **Mechanism:** Zepbound acts on two receptors (GIP and GLP-1), whereas Wegovy acts on one (GLP-1).
- **Effectiveness:** average weight loss is greater with Zepbound — about 19 to 21% of initial body weight after 72 weeks at the 10–15 mg doses (about 1 in 2 patients loses 20% or more at the maximum dose), compared to about 15% with Wegovy. In people with diabetes, weight loss is about 13 to 15%.
- **How it's taken:** same frequency (1 injection per week), but the pen is different — a multi-dose pen with 4 doses per month.
- **Side effects:** overall similar profile, dominated by digestive effects; injection site reactions and mild hair loss are reported somewhat more often with Zepbound.
- **Interaction specific to Zepbound:** temporarily reduced effectiveness of oral contraceptives (see precautions above) — this precaution does not apply to Wegovy.
- **Cost:** comparable price range (\$300 to \$540/month depending on the dose), but no generic tirzepatide is expected for several years, whereas generic versions of semaglutide (Wegovy) have been available since the summer of 2026 and may reduce costs.
- **Track record:** marketed more recently in Canada (2025).

Recommended Follow-Up

Regular medical follow-up is necessary to adjust the dose, monitor tolerance, and evaluate the benefits. If you have diabetes, blood sugar monitoring is also recommended.